

Asking Your Employer: The Reference Letter Request Template

A ready-to-send letter that asks HR for an Express Entry reference letter - and gets a compliant one back the first time.

Most non-compliant reference letters are not the employer's fault - they were never told what IRCC requires. HR departments issue standard service certificates that omit duties, hours, and salary, and each corrected round trip costs weeks. This template puts the full IRCC specification in the request itself.

The tactic that saves a month

Send the request in writing, attach the specification below, and offer a pre-written draft your employer can put on letterhead. Employers sign accurate drafts far faster than they write letters from scratch.

The request letter

Subject: Request for employment reference letter - [your full name], [employee ID]

Dear [HR manager / supervisor name],

I am preparing an application for Canadian permanent residence under Express Entry, and Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) requires a reference letter from my employer in a specific format. I would be grateful if you could issue a letter meeting the requirements below.

The letter should be printed on company letterhead, and must include:

1. My full name as per company records;
2. The company's address, telephone number, and email address;
3. The name, title, and signature of my immediate supervisor or a personnel officer;
4. All positions I have held at the company, and for each: job title, duties and responsibilities, job status (for my current role), dates worked, number of work hours per week, and annual salary plus benefits.

To make this as easy as possible, I have attached a draft containing the factual details, which you are welcome to verify, amend, and place on letterhead.

This letter is for immigration documentation only and creates no obligation for the company. I would appreciate receiving it by [date], as my application is time-bound.

Thank you for your help.

Sincerely,
[Your name]
[Department / employee ID]
[Phone - email]

If the company refuses or no longer exists

- Ask your direct supervisor (current or former) to sign the letter in a personal capacity, stating their role, and pair it with supporting evidence: employment contract, pay slips, promotion letters, tax records.

- If no letter is obtainable at all, assemble the alternative evidence and explain the situation in a Letter of Explanation - an officer can accept a documented, credible account of why the standard letter is unavailable.
- Never submit a letter you drafted and signed yourself as if it came from the company - that is misrepresentation territory.

Sources

Every rule and figure in this document was verified against the following official pages on 19 July 2026:

- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/corporate/publications-manuals/operational-bulletins-manuals/permanent-residence/express-entry/applications-received-on-after-january-1-2016-completeness-check.html

Important - please read

The information provided is for informational and guidance purposes only, based on publicly available Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) regulations and policies. This does not constitute legal advice, and no solicitor-client or consultant-client relationship is created by accessing this content. Immigration regulations, program requirements, processing times, and CRS cutoff scores are subject to frequent change without notice. You are responsible for verifying all information with official IRCC sources (www.canada.ca/immigration) and confirming current eligibility requirements before taking any action.